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Re-examining and Contextualizing the 686/1287 Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' from Early Ilkhanid Baghdad (Ms Istanbul, Süleymaniye, Esad Efendi 3638)

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Abstract

The *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'* (Epistles of the Brethren of Purity and Loyal Friends), copied in Baghdad in 686/1287 and kept in the Süleymaniye Library in Istanbul, is known for its double page frontispiece, headed by the names of the authors and the book title, and painted with an image of debating scholars surrounded by luxurious architecture [Fig. 1]. The copy features diagrams and tables and is of interest for the study of medieval manuscript traditions of the *Rasā'il*. This article re-examines the codex, expanding observations and insights into its history. It discusses the function of the frontispiece, which has been perceived as an authors' portrait in the succession of pre-Mongol Arab book painting, but is unique among known *Rasā'il* copies. Reviewing the text on the double page and considering that the *Rasā'il* was an anonymous book, we argue that the frontispiece advertised a particular opinion and reference regarding the authorship, visualized and emphasised through the medium of the figural image. Situating the copy in the scholarly book production of early Ilkhanid Baghdad under the Persian Juwaynī governors from early Ilkhanid Iran, the article examines how that time and place are referenced in the painting. Extending the question to the unknown patron and his milieu, it discusses figures with portrait-like faces presenting a book as possible references to the Juwaynīs. We suggest to see the novelty of the painting not only in its style and close text-image relation, but in its function as editorial statement and in the layered references. These evidence a concept of visual commentary on both history and present, that has been argued for Ilkhanid painting of northwest Iran, but was used here several decades earlier in Baghdad.

Keywords

Arab and Persian book painting – art patronage – Ilkhanid Baghdad – Juvayni family – frontispiece – author portrait – crypto-portrait – *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*

1 The *Rasā'il* Codex Esad Efendi 3638

The *Rasā'il* book is well-known as an encyclopaedia of knowledge and philosophy across various fields that harmonizes late antique sciences and Islamic disciplines. The author and date are unknown, and the book is often referred to as being close to Shiite or Ismaili traditions. The text is attributed to sometime in the ninth to tenth centuries CE, or earlier.¹ It comprises 52 chapters (*risāla*, epistle, letter) organized into four sections on mathematical, logical, natural, and divine sciences, an explanatory table of contents prefacing the text (*fihris*t), and a compendium (*risālat al-jāmi'a*) at the end.²

The 686/1287 copy from Baghdad entered the Süleymaniye Library in 1262/1848 as part of the collection of the Ottoman bibliophile Mehmed Esad Efendi (1204–1264/1789–1848).³ Bishr Farès briefly introduced the manuscript and the frontispiece in an article (1957), Richard Ettinghausen mentions it in his *Arab Painting* (1962), Robert Hillenbrand and other art historians have discussed the frontispiece paintings, while Nourane Ben Azzouna has briefly surveyed the codicological structure of the manuscript.⁴ I examined Esad Efendi 3638 in the

1 On the *Rasā'il*, see Yves Marquet, s. v. "Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'," in: *ET*², vol. 3 (1971), 1071–1076; Susanne Diwald, *Arabische Philosophie und Wissenschaft in der Enzyklopädie Kitāb Iḥwān aṣ-Ṣafā'; die Lehre von Seele und Intellekt* (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1975); Dimitri Gutas, Paraskevi Kotzia, Eva Orthmann and Daniel De Smet, "The Dissemination of Philosophical Thought," in: Ulrich Rudolph, Rotraud Hansberger and Peter Adamson (eds.), *Philosophy in the Islamic World*, vol. 1, *8th–10th Centuries* (Leiden: Brill, 2015), 749–759; and Nader El-Bizri, Prologue, in: El-Bizri (ed.) *Epistles of the Brethren of Purity: The Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' and their Rasā'il: An Introduction* (Oxford: University Press, 2008), 1–32; see also contributions by other scholars in the same volume.

2 El-Bizri 2008, 13; Godefroid De Calataj, "The Classification of Knowledge in the *Rasā'il*," in: El-Bizri, (ed.) 2008, 86; Ismail K. Poonawala, "Why We Need an Arabic Critical Edition with an Annotated English Translation of the *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā'*," in: El-Bizri (ed.) 2008, 41.

3 On him, see M. Münir Aktepe, s. v. "Es'ad Efendi, Mehmed," in: *ET*², vol. 2 (1965), 713–714; *idem*, s. v. "Es'ad Efendi," in: *İslam Ansiklopedisi*, edited by. A. Adivar, R. Arat, A. Ateş, İ. Kafesoğlu, T. Yazıcı, vol. 4 (Istanbul: Milli Eğitim Basımevi, 1977), 363a–365b.

4 Bishr Farès, "Philosophie et jurisprudence illustrée par les Arabes. La querelle des images en Islam," in: *Mélanges Louis Massignon*, 3 vols. (Damascus: Institut français de Damas, 1957),

Süleymaniye Library in the summer of 2020,⁵ and the following observations add some evidence and help to clarify the history of the codex.

The codex has been re-bound in dark-brown leather, with an impressed gold décor on the front and back sides. This decoration includes a rectangular frame along the edges and a poly-lobed medallion with radiating strokes, filled with a flower scroll design, at the centre. The design is comparable to the type classified by François Déroche as “bouquets à depart interieur” in Ottoman bindings dating from the sixteenth to nineteenth centuries CE.⁶

The *Rasā'il* copy comprises an incomplete preface, the double-page frontispiece, and 52 chapters, ending with a page that is only preserved as a fragment. The first folio, which is not part of the text, has been added later. Including all these elements, the manuscript has 324 folios.⁷ There are two foliations, neither of them original, written with pencil in the top-left corner of each *recto* side. A foliation in European Arabic numerals is written above the end of the first line. It starts on fol. 2, running through until the last folio, numbered 323. A foliation in Hindu-Arabic numerals is written on the outer margin. It starts on the added fol. 1 but skips the folio numbered “63” in European Arabic numerals; it, too, runs until fol. 323. From fol. 64 onwards, the numbering of both foliations is identical. This article refers to the foliation in Hindu-Arabic numerals, which has been used in earlier publications.

The folio size is 31.5 × 22 cm and was originally larger.⁸ The outer margins have been cropped at some time, probably when the manuscript received its present Ottoman binding. Glosses in the outer margins have partly been cut away, notably in the last third of the manuscript, together with the catchwords

vol. 2, 78–79; Richard Ettinghausen, *Arabische Malerei* (Geneva: Skira, 1962), 98–99, 101 (see below for further art historical writing); Nourane Ben Azzouna, *Aux origines du classicisme. Calligraphes et bibliophiles au temps des dynasties mongoles (Les Ilkhanides et les Djalayirides 656–814/1258–1411)* (Leiden: Brill, 2018), 551–552. Cf. observations on the manuscript in volumes of the ongoing critical edition of the *Rasā'il* text (Oxford: University Press), so far with volumes on chapters 1–8, 10–22, 32–36, 39–41, 43–45, and 48–52/1.

5 On 31 August 2020. Observations were also checked against high-resolution photos of all of the manuscript's pages. I would like to express my thanks, for the permission to access the manuscript, to the directorate of the Süleymaniye Kütüphanesi in Istanbul; for insight into the *Rasā'il*, to Elvira Wakelnig; and for comments, to Nourane Ben Azzouna, Suzanne Compagnon, Nader El-Bizri and Sabiha Göloğlu.

6 See François Déroche, *Catalogue des manuscrits arabes*, Partie 2, *Manuscrits musulmans*, Tome 1, *Les manuscrits du Coran*, 2, *Du Maghreb à l'Insulinde* (Paris: Bibliothèque nationale, 1985), 22–25.

7 Farès 1957, 78, and Ben Azzouna 2018, 551, noted 323 folios.

8 While the height is consistent, the width varies slightly, for example 22 cm in fols. 56–57 and 23.1 cm in fols. 176–177. Ben Azzouna 2018, 551: 31.45 × 23.7 cm; Farès 1957, 78: 32 × 22 cm.

on the bottom margin of the *verso* pages. The cream paper is of good quality. Folios 49–63 are a later replacement: the paper is of a lighter colour, the handwriting differs, and the catchwords in the margins are not cropped. The slip in numbering fol. 64 in the Hindu-Arabic foliation numerals probably relates to this replacement. Folios are missing in at least two places of the last third of the manuscript, where the catchwords do not fit. There are usually 35 lines of writing per page, covering an average text area of 25×17.3 cm. Grooves of regular line ruling indicate the use of a ruling board, or *miṣṭara*. The writing is in black ink, with a clear *naskh*, rarely vocalized. The manuscript looks well preserved, but damage from water, mould, worms, and cuts can increasingly be seen from about fol. 235 to the end. The long edges of fols. 1–4 have been secured and extended more recently with white paper strips folded and glued around them.⁹ [Figs. 1–2]

All that remains of the original fol. 323 is a fragment with a colophon, a cut piece of paper measuring 9–9.2×20.5 cm, pasted onto a more recent white sheet, which constitutes fol. 323a, the last page in the present manuscript. As the paper of this sheet looks similar to the blank flyleaf before fol. 1, the cutting and preservation of the fragment seem to date from the time of the Ottoman rebinding. This begs the question whether, after this point, more folios from the original manuscript are missing.¹⁰

Fol. 1 in the bound codex has been added later. The paper is darker than the other folios, and the layout differs. The first page shows two columns and a stamp of the Esad Efendi collection with the handwritten number “3638.” In the right column, a centred headline reads “*fī Tārīkh Ibn Shākir*,” followed by 23 lines of Arabic text from an entry on the authors of the *Rasā'il* in a biographical book by the Damascene Ibn Shākir (d. 764/1363).¹¹ The left column

9 For details on paper and quires, see Ben Azzouna 2018, 551–552, who notes the *lacunae* between folios 213/214 and 293/294, but claims an absence of vocalization and a replacement of fols. 48–72.

10 A later, clumsily written note on the margin of the fragment reads “*‘adad warqa thalāthumī’a* (the number of sheets is three hundred)” followed by what looks like the cipher 88 and by the letter *‘ayn*. If that meant a reference to an original larger number of 388 folios, the manuscript would have continued beyond this point. This could have been the compendium part of the *Rasā'il* book or another accompanying treatise.

11 The text refers first to “Zayd ibn ‘Abdallāh ibn Rifā’a al-Hāshimī,” to be identified as Abū ‘Abdallāh Muḥammad ibn Shākir al-Dārānī al-Dimashqī al-Kutubī. On him, see Heidi Krauss-Sánchez, s. v. “al-Kutubī, Ibn Shākir,” in: Graeme Dunphy and Cristian Bratu (eds.), *Encyclopedia of the Medieval Chronicle*, 2 vols. (Leiden et al.: Brill, 2010), vol. 2, 985. Ibn Shākir worked in Damascus and wrote *Fawāt al-wafāt* (Beyond the Obituaries), an alphabetically organized biographical work, and *Uyūn al-tawārikh* (Wellsprings of Histories), a bio-bibliography of learned and important persons. Manuscripts of both books, which

notes the *Rasā'il* book title. Below it, two casually written sloping lines of Arabic read: "*wa-mimmā qālahu Ṣaḥfī al-Ḥillī fī dīwānihi fī qaṣīdat [...]*" (from what Ṣaḥfī al-Ḥillī said in his *Dīwān* in the *qaṣīda*), followed by a quote from that poem in the second line. This note refers to the *Dīwān* of the Shiite litterateur Ṣaḥfī al-Dīn al-Ḥillī (677–752/1278–1349), who is considered the most celebrated Arabic-language poet of the eighth/fourteenth century.¹² Above the book title on the *recto*, fol. 1a, is a note of five lines in a triangular shape. The *verso* of the added folio, fol. 1b, otherwise blank, shows a larger written note of seven lines. Both notes appear to be by an Ottoman hand. According to the reading by Claudia Römer, the *recto* note is a record of ownership by "Seyyid Meḥmed [...] ibn-i Seyyid Yaḥyā," scribe of the Ottoman Deputy Grand Vizier. The *verso* note comments that some statements in the *Rasā'il* run counter to the Sharia while others are consistent with "the book *Mabāhith al-mashriqiyya* of Imām Muḥammad Rāzī." It must refer to the work of the philosopher and theologian Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī (d. 605/1209).¹³ This is a reminder of the criticism that the *Rasā'il* received from some schools of thought.

The original first folio and beginning of the manuscript are missing. The preface, or *fihrist*, starts abruptly, on fol. 2a in the middle of a sentence, with "*min al-ṣīdaq [...]*" and continues in the following sentence with a comment on the *Seventeenth Risāla*, clearly indicating that the text before is missing [Fig. 3]. The remainder covers three pages, fols. 2a–3a, featuring the same layout and writing style as the following *Rasā'il* chapters. It constitutes a commented table of contents, briefly explaining the chapters of the *Rasā'il*. This kind of preface was common in copies of the *Rasā'il*.¹⁴ The Esad Efendi 3638 version is much shorter and deviates in some places from the wording of the modern printed edition of Buṭrus al-Bustānī. Analogously, the missing part of the preface in the

may have been used by the writer of the text on fol. 1a, exist in Istanbul: Topkapı Sarayı Müzesi Kütüphanesi (hereafter TSMK), Ahmet III, 2921 and 2922.

12 On him, see W[olfhart] P. Heinrichs, s. v. "Ṣaḥfī al-Dīn 'Abd al-'Azīz b. Sarāyā al-Ḥillī," in: *ET*², vol. 8 (1995), 801–805.

13 On fol. 1a: "*Istaṣḥabahu el-faqīr el-seyyid Meḥmed | [...] ibn-i seyyid Yaḥyā | Ser-khulefā ve kātīb-i | Ketkhūdā-yi ṣadr-i 'ālī | 'uḥfiye 'anhümā.*" On fol. 1b: "*Ṭāla'tu hādhdā al-kitāb fī [...] i al-aḥqāt bi-'ināyati rabbi al-arbāb | wa-wajadtu fihī ba'd aḡwāl mukhālīfan li-zāhiri al-shar' wa-lākin | aktharu mas'āli al-ḥikmiyya allatī adrajtū fī maṭāwihi | muwāfiqan li-mā fī kitābi Mabāhithi al-mashriqiyya | li-imām Muḥammad Rāzī | raḥimahu Llāh | anā al-faqīr ilayhi ta'ālā | raḥīq [...] Llāhu lahu | al-faqīr [...]* (signature)." I am grateful to Claudia Römer for reading the two notes, and to Nazlı Vatansever for a comment on the handwriting.

14 Poonawala 2008, 41; Abbas Hamdani, "The Arrangement of the *Rasā'il* Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' and the Problem of Interpolations," in: El-Bizri (ed.) 2008, 89.



FIGURE 1 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, Baghdad 686/1287. Double-page frontispiece with text and two paintings on right and left pages. Water colour and ink on paper, each framed area 25 × 17.7 cm. MS Istanbul, Süleymaniye Yazma Eser Kütüphanesi (SYEK), Esad Efendi 3638, fols. 3b–4a
 PHOTO © SYEK



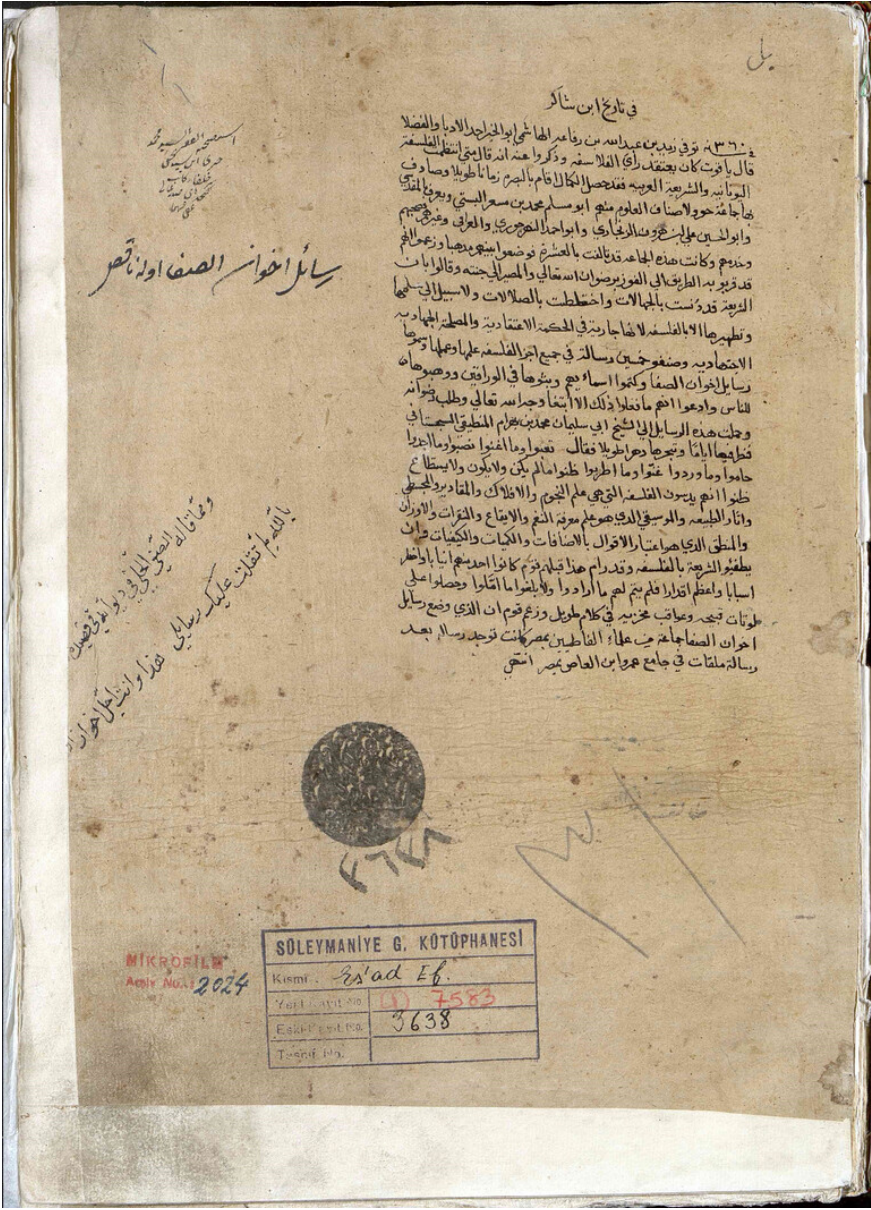


FIGURE 2 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, Baghdad 686/1287, showing the *recto* side of the added first folio. ms Istanbul, Esad Efendi 3638, fol. 1a
PHOTO © SYEK

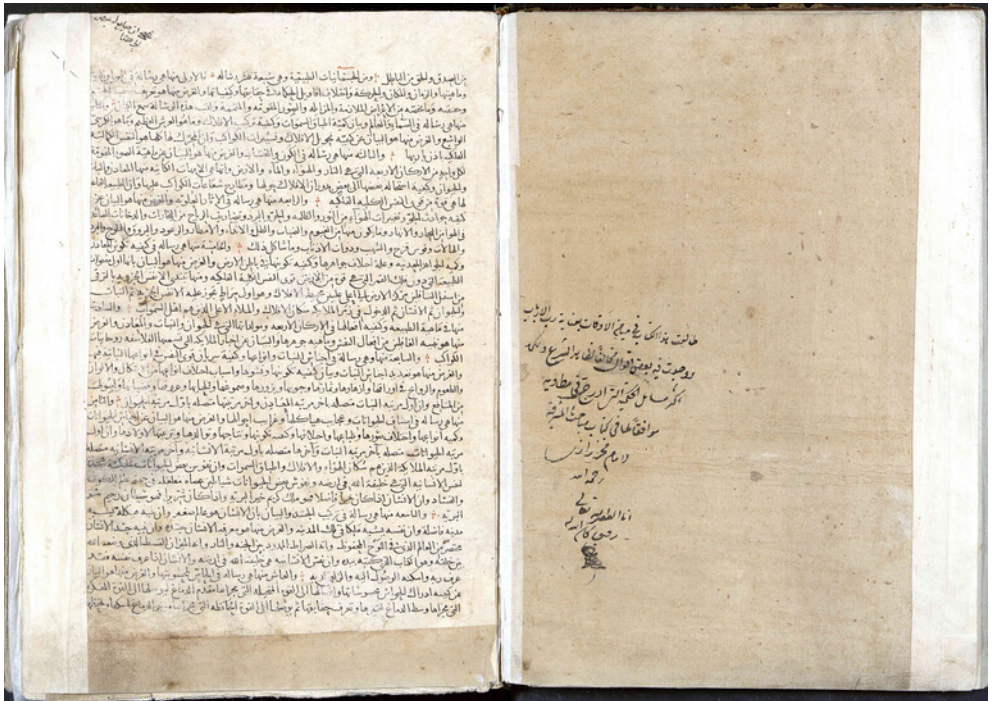


FIGURE 3 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, Baghdad 686/1287, showing the verso of the added first folio and the *recto* of the first extant original folio. MS Istanbul, Esad Efendi 3638, fols. 1b–2a

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manuscript would not have filled more than one page.¹⁵ If it had been a bifolio, as elsewhere in the manuscript,¹⁶ four pages would be missing: the last, a *verso*, with the beginning of the preface, and another three, which would have constituted an opening section with the title-page.

The main text of the *Rasā'il* starts with the *First Risāla* on fol. 4b, after the painted double-page frontispiece on fols. 3b–4a. It comprises 51 *rasā'il* in four sections (*qism*), and an additional *risāla* also numbered 51, hence a total of 52

15 Anonymous, *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-Ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, edited by Buṭrus al-Bustānī, 4 vols. (Beirut: Dār Ṣādir and Dār Bayrūt; reprint Beirut: Dār Bayrūt li-al-ṭibā'at wa-al-nashr, 1983). In this edition, the preface with annotations runs over 26 pages from pp. 21 to 47; the comment on Chapter 17 starts on p. 26. The phrase "*Wa-ī'lam ayyuka [...]*" on fol. 3a, line 29, before the end of the preface in the manuscript, corresponds to "*Wa-ī'lam yā akhī, ayyuka [...]*" on p. 43 in the printed edition. In the manuscript, seven and a half lines of text follow, while in the edition it is a further four pages.

16 Suggested by Ben Azzouna 2018, 552.

chapters. Red ink was used for the beginning of chapters and sections (*faṣl*), emphasized text, section markers in the shape of three dots and one stroke, occasional overlining, and in the tables, drawings, and diagrams. The first six *rasā'il*, or chapters, through fol. 39b, contain drawn diagrams and tables within the text; a further diagram and table are found on fols. 76b and 208a [Fig. 4]. The chapters (see the index in note 17) start with the title and the number of the *risāla*, or the number within the respective part (*qism*) of the *Rasā'il*. Sometimes, both numbers are indicated, in one case there is only the title. The *Fifty-First Risāla*, the eleventh *risāla* in the fourth section, ends on fol. 302b. A three-line heading on top of the following page introduces a further chapter, on fols. 303a–322b, as an alternative eleventh *risāla* of the fourth section.¹⁷ These two alternative final chapters and the overall number of 52 chapters are common in medieval copies of the *Rasā'il*.

The manuscript has two colophons, each at the end of one of the two final chapters. The obvious colophon at the very end of the manuscript on fol. 323a has been mentioned by Farès,¹⁸ while a preceding colophon, on fol. 302b, went unnoticed and is published here in Figure 5. The existence of two colophons underlines that each of the two final chapters was presented equally as an alternative ending to the book. The same copyist has signed both, but the date differs by one month.

The first colophon, on fol. 302b [Fig. 5], is written at the lower end of the page, in five indented lines, after which there is an empty line followed by three lines in triangular formatting, with the copyist's name and the date. The text states that the chapter has been finished, and with it this section and the entire *Rasā'il*, and it ends with religious formulas. In the final triangular-shaped paragraph, the copyist states his name Buzurjmīhr (analogous to Bozorgmehr in Persian spelling), son of Muḥammad, with the *nisba* al-Ṭūsī, the place (Madī-

17 Index of chapter beginnings: chapter 1: fol. 4b—2: 9a—3: 14a—4: 23a—5: 26a—6 of part (*qism*) 1: 36a—7: 40a—8: 3a—9: 46a—10: 62b—11: 64a—12: 66a—13: 68b—14: 72b—15: 76b—16: 80b—17: 84b—18 = 5 of *Ṭabī'yyāt*: 87a—[19 =] 7 of part 2: 94b—[20 =] 8/2: 99a—[21 =] 9/2: 129b—[22 =] 10/2: 133a—[23 =] 11/2: 136b—[24 =] 12/2: 143b—[25 =] 13/2: 147b—[26 =] 14/2: 149b—[27 =] 15/2: 152a—[28 =] 16/2: 154b—[29 =] 17/2: 159b—[30 =] *Risālat al-mabādī 'alā ra'y*: 175b—31 = 1/3: 177b—33 = 2/3: 180b—34 = 4/2: 182a—35 = 5/3: 185a—36 = 6/3: 188a—37 = 7/3: 191a—38 = 8/3: 197a—39 = 9/3: 201a—40 = 10/3: 209a—[41 =] 1/4: 210b—[42 =] 2/4: 233b—[43 =] 3/4: 235a—[44 =] 4/4: 240a—[45 =] 5/4: 243a—[46 =] 6/4: 254a—[47 =] 7/4: 258b—[48 =] 8/4: 268a—[49 =] 9/4: 276a—50 = 10/4: 282a—51 = 11/4: 284a, the end is on fol. 302a. The count jumps at chapters 31 = 1/3 and 33 = 2/3, skipping 32; and at 18 = 5/2 and [19 =] 7/2, skipping 6/2; but the overall number of chapters remains 52.

18 Farès 1957, 78, pl. Iva, discussed briefly and with a reproduction that precludes a clear reading; cf. Ben Azzouna 2018, 551.



FIGURE 4 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, Baghdad 686/1287, Ms Istanbul, Esad Efendi 3638, fols. 16b–17a, showing text with diagrams in the *Fourth Risāla*

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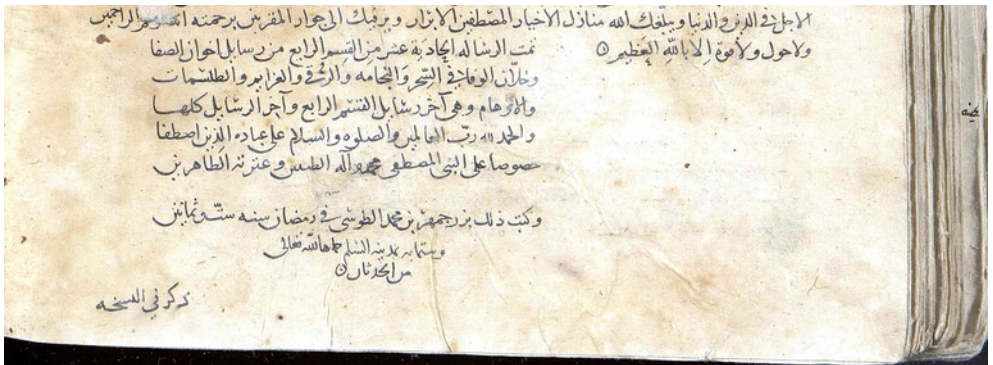


FIGURE 5 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, Baghdad 686/1287, Ms Istanbul, Esad Efendi 3638, first colophon, detail of fol. 302b

PHOTO © SYEK

nat al-Salām, written with defective *alif*) and the date (Ramaḍān 686), which corresponds to Baghdad in October–November 1287 CE:¹⁹

تمت الرسالة الحادية عشر من القسم الرابع من رسائل اخوان الصفا | وخلان الوفا في السحر
والنجامة والرقى والعزائم والطلسمات | والاولهام وهي آخر رسائل القسم الرابع وآخر الرسائل
كلها | والحمد لله رب العالمين والصلوة والسلام على عباده الذين اصطفى | خصوصا على النبي
المصطفى محمد وآله الطيبين وعترته الطاهرين
وكتب ذلك بزرجمهر بن محمد الطوسي في رمضان سنة ست وثمانين | وستماية بمدينة السلم
حماها الله تعالى | من الحدثان

The *Eleventh Risāla* in the fourth section of the *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafa wa khullān al-wafā'*, on magic, astrology, spells, curses, talismans, and idols, has ended. It is the last of the *rasā'il* in the fourth section and the last of the entire *Rasā'il*. Praise be to God, Lord of the worlds, and prayers and peace be upon His worshippers who follow the chosen Prophet Muḥammad and His family of pure ones.

This has been written by Buzurjmihr ibn Muḥammad al-Ṭūsī in Ramaḍān of the year six hundred and eighty-six in Madīnat al-Sal[ā]m, may God the Exalted protect it from evil events.

The second colophon [Fig. 6] is the only part that remains of the original fol. 323a. The first line of text on the fragment continues an ending formula from the preceding page. There then follows a colophon of seven indented lines, in the same style of writing, which reads:

تمت الرسالة الحادية عشر من القسم الرابع الناموسى الالهى | من جملة إحدى وخمسين رساله
من رسائل اخوان الصفا | وخلان الوفا في تهذيب النفس واصلاح الاخلاق على يدى | العبد
الضعيف المحتاج الى رحمه ربه اللطيف بزرجمهر | ابن محمد الطوسى احسن الله عاقبته في شوال
سنه ست وثمانين | وستماية بمدينة السلم حماها الله من الافات | حامدا لله تعالى ومصليا على
نبيه وآله الطاهرين ومسلما

19 Ramaḍān 686 AH started on 10.10.1287 CE.



FIGURE 6 *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā'*, Baghdad 686/1287, Ms Istanbul, Esad Efendi 3638, second colophon on fol. 323a, fragment of original sheet pasted onto the more recent and current last folio
PHOTO © SYEK

The *Eleventh Risāla* in the fourth section on divine law, of all fifty-one chapters of the *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafa wa khullān al-wafā'*, has ended, through cleansing of the soul and refining the character, by the two hands of the weak servant, in need of the mercy of his gentle Lord, Buzurjmihr ibn Muḥammad al-Ṭūsī, may God reward him, in Shawwāl of the year six hundred and eighty-six in Madīnat al-Sal[ā]m, may God protect her from ill-being. Praise be to God the Exalted, and prayers for His Prophet and his family of the pure and righteous.

This text repeats the first colophon in different phrasing, noting that it is Chapter 51 of the entire *Rasā'il*. It introduces the signature with "*fī tahdhīb al-naḥs wa-islāḥ al-akhlāq*," considered a Sufi notion,²⁰ and the phrase "by the two hands of (*'alā yaday*).²¹ Like the first colophon, this is followed by the copyist's name, his *nisba* spelled al-Ṭūsī,²¹ and the location. The date is now in the follow-

20 On this expression, see Poonawala 2008, 47.

21 Inaccurately transliterated al-Ṭūsī by Farès 1957, 78, and al-Ṭūsī by Ben Azzouna 2018, 551.

ing month (Shawwāl 686), equivalent to November–December 1287 CE.²² The final sentence, similar to the end of the first paragraph in the first colophon, is a eulogy on God, the Prophet Muḥammad, and his family.

The double page with painting on fols. 3b–4a is usually called a frontispiece although it is not situated at the beginning of the book, but rather between the preface and the first chapter of the *Rasā'il*. The back sides, fols. 3a and 4b, prove that it was an integral part of the original manuscript as they carry the text that ends the preface and begins the *First Risāla*. The paintings are set in a double-lined frame measuring 20.3 × 17.4 and 17.5 cm internally, and with the text above them 25 × 17.7 cm externally, on the right and left pages.²³ They are mostly known through the reproductions in Ettinghausen's *Arab Painting*, which were often re-reproduced but display only part of the double page and have exaggerated colours.²⁴ Figure 1 in this contribution shows the full double page with the subdued original colours. Both paintings are damaged by holes in the paper, also visible on the reverse, and apparently caused by an aggressive substance in the green paint. They have been repaired twice with patches on the back side.²⁵

From these observations, a history of the manuscript based on internal evidence starts to unfold. One can only speculate on the missing folios at the beginning, and probably the end of the manuscript. We can be certain that one missing folio contained the beginning of the preface on the *verso* page. The *recto* would likely have been the title-page, or it would have formed a larger opening part together with one or more preceding folios, possibly with another frontispiece. In any case, the missing first pages would have recorded, if not the patron, early owners of the manuscript, just as Ottoman owners later left notes on the added fol. 1. The original beginning may not have been lost accidentally but removed intentionally in order to obscure earlier owners, a note of bequest or *waqf* of an institution, or the patron. We now turn to the preserved double-page frontispiece to demonstrate that one of its functions was to announce, through text and image, a position in the medieval debate on the authorship of the book.

22 Shawwāl 686 AH started on 9 November 1287 CE.

23 Cf. slightly differing measurements by Ettinghausen 1962, 98–99, and Farès 1957, 78.

24 Ettinghausen 1962, 98–99, 101. Re-reproductions of these photos have been published often. Farès 1957, pl. 2–3, provided two separate black-and-white reproductions.

25 Most holes were patched by paper strips glued in various directions, covering part of the text. A second smaller piece of paper has been glued over some strips, which looks lighter and indicates another, later repair. In a few places, thin transparent paper has been glued more recently over the holes. A few transparent or uncovered holes reveal the writing of the page behind it.

2 The Frontispiece as Opinion in a Debate: The *Rasā'il* Authors after al-Bayhaqī

The double-page frontispiece [Fig. 1] presents the painting and text, together with their surrounding frame, as closely linked entities. The paintings are headed by two text boxes in large writing. The right-hand page names five authors of the *Rasā'il*, the left-hand page displays the book title in monumental lettering. The two paintings are populated by a total of fourteen male figures in a two-storey structure: a lofty ground floor is divided by columns into three sections and a lower gallery with four arcades. In each painting, a group of three large figures in scholarly attire is sitting in the broad middle section, two small servant figures are standing to attention at the sides, and two small scholar figures sit in the upper gallery. The calligrapher and painter of the frontispiece are unknown. The colophons are silent, but the copyist Buzurjmihr ibn Muḥammad al-Ṭūsī may also have written the text in the frontispiece.²⁶ On the lower margin of the right page, and in the two broken-headed arches of the painted brickwork on both pages, three vertically written words can be made out, which have not been mentioned or deciphered.

In modern scholarship, the two paintings have been discussed as an author portrait. There is general agreement that they depict the five *Rasā'il* authors mentioned in the heading on the right-hand page, with different explanations as to who each figures. Farès interpreted the five large and small seated figures of each page as the authors, shown twice in different activities on the right and left pages. Ettinghausen, instead, convincingly proposed that both pages together form one image. He described the six large, seated figures on the ground floor as the five authors and a scribe. The latter would have been added for formal symmetry, according to Robert Hillenbrand, who saw the chief author and redactor in the middle figure on the right page. Sheila Blair has explained the six large figures as the five authors and the scholar al-Bayhaqī, who is mentioned in the text above the paintings.²⁷ I agree with this under-

26 The *Maqāmāt* copy dated 634/1237, Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France (hereafter BnF), Arabe 5847, was both transcribed and illustrated by the same person, Yaḥyā al-Wāsiṭī; see Ettinghausen 1962, 115.

27 Farès 1957, 79, 82–83, pls. II–III; Ettinghausen 1962, 98–103; Robert Hillenbrand, "Erudition Exalted: The Double Frontispiece to the Epistles of the Sincere Brethren," in: Linda Komaroff (ed.), *Beyond the Legacy of Genghis Khan* (Leiden: Brill, 2007), 187 n. 22, 204, 210; Sheila Blair, "Une brève histoire des portraits d'auteurs dans les manuscrits islamiques," in: Houari Touati (ed.), *De la figuration humaine au portrait dans l'art islamique* (Leiden et al.: Brill, 2015), 54–55; cf. Eva R. Hoffman, "The Author Portrait in Thirteenth-Century Arabic Manuscripts: A New Islamic Context for a Late-Antique Tradition," *Muqarnas* 10 (1993),

standing and the emphasis on the relation between text and painting, yet my interpretation of the individual figures and reading of the text differs, as I will now explain.

The visual significance and function of this frontispiece become apparent when we remember that the *Rasā'il* is an anonymous work, and that its authorship was hotly debated. As the book relates to philosophy, its content was also disputed, contested, and sometimes rejected. This is nicely attested in the Esad Efendi copy by the later study note on fol. 1b, which refers to a medieval critique by Muḥammad Rāzī from circa 1200 CE. Various opinions on the author(s), some rather imaginative, were expressed in medieval times, and in fact the debate on who wrote the *Rasā'il* continues today in modern scholarship. One widespread, though not universally accepted medieval opinion rested on the Abbasid litterateur and intellectual al-Tawḥīdī in Baghdad, who reported that the *Rasā'il* book was compiled by a group of contemporaneous authors in Basra. He named four of them and a further fifth person.²⁸

The right-hand heading in the frontispiece of the Esad Efendi copy states almost the same opinion, but with some significant differences in the order of the names, their presentation, and their spelling. It does so by referring to, and in fact quoting from, a work by the scholar al-Bayhaqī from Saljuq Khurasan. For clarification, the reading of the headline text is considered again here, adjusting some inaccuracies and misunderstandings in previous scholarship [Fig. 1]:²⁹

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- 7 n. 7. François Déroche, *Le livre manuscrit arabe. Préludes à une histoire* (Paris: Bibliothèque nationale de France, 2004), 48, fig. 32, viewed the central figure on the right page as an example of the depiction of an author reciting his work to a copyist. Persis Berlekamp, *Wonder, Image, and Cosmos in Medieval Islam* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2011), 51, speculated without argument that the sixth figure could be Aristotle.
- 28 Marquet 1971; Diwald 1975, 8–16; El-Bizri 2008, 8–9; Hamdani 2008, 83–85; Gutas, Kotzia, Orthmann and De Smet 2016, 752–753; the most recent and new suggestion is by Guillaume De Vault D'Arcy, "Aḥmad b. al-Ṭayyib al-Saraḥsī, réviseur de l'*Introduction arithmétique* de Nicomaque de Gêrèse et rédacteur des *Rasā'il Iḥwān al-Ṣafā'*," *Arabic Sciences and Philosophy* 29 (2019), 261–283.
- 29 Farès 1957, 56–57, read "al-Muḥaddasī," but in both occurrences the name is written with *kasra* below the *dāl*, and the *shadda* is above the ending, hence "al-Maqdisī," and instead of "Zahrān" it is clearly written "Zahrūn." He opted for spelling "az-Zindjānī," with *kasra*. Ettinghausen 1962, 101–102, read the names correctly, except again "Zahrān" instead of "Zahrūn." He also followed Farès' spelling of "az-Zinjānī." Hillenbrand 2006, 183–184, read "Zahrūn" correctly and opted for "al-Zanjānī." Blair 2015, 54, read "al-Ma'sar" erroneously, while the writing shows first the *sin* and second the *ayn*; and instead of her "Zāhrūn" it is written "Zahrūn." She understood the half-circle over that name as a *sukūn*, but this cannot be the case judging from its use in other places of the text.

نقل من تمة صوّان الحكمة لظهير الدين أبي القسم البيهقي ان خمسةً من الحكماء اجتمعوا [١] |
وصنّفوا رسائل اخوان الصّفا وهم ابو سليمان محمد بن مسعر البُستيّ ويعرف بالمقدسيّ وابو
الحسن | علي بن زهرون الزنجانيّ وابو احمد النهرجوريّ والعوفيّ وزيد بن رفاعه والفاط الكتاب
للمقدسيّ

It has been transmitted (*nuqila* or *naqlun*) from the *Tatimmat Šiwān al-ḥikma* of (*li-*) Ṣāḥir al-Dīn [Ibn] 'Abī al-Qasim al-Bayhaqī that five of the learned men (*ḥukamā'*) collected | and compiled the *Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā'*, and they are: Abū Sulayman [*sic*] Muḥammad ibn Mas'ar (or: Mis'ar, etc.) al-Bustī, known as al-Maqdisī, and Abū al-Ḥasan | 'Alī ibn Zahrūn al-Zanjānī (or: al-Zinjānī), and Abū Aḥmad al-Nahrajūrī, and al-'Awfī, and Zayd ibn Rifā'a; and the wording of the book (*alfāz al-kitāb*) is by al-Maqdisī.³⁰

The passage advertises, firstly, the scholarly source from which the authors are cited, the book *Tatimmat Šiwān al-ḥikma* by al-Bayhaqī; it then proceeds to give five names of the authors of the *Rasā'il*. The passage ends with information about which of the five was the redactor. The preposition *li-* before al-Bayhaqī must be read as a genitive paraphrase of the pattern *kitābun lahu*, which records him as the author of the preceding book *Tatimma*.³¹ This was correctly understood by Farès. A reading that al-Bayhaqī was informed by this book, as suggested by Hillenbrand, or that the *Rasā'il* was compiled for him, as posited by Blair, is neither supported by the text nor is it compatible with the fact that the author of the *Tatimma* was al-Bayhaqī.³² It is also mistaken to see

30 My transcription notes some of the diacritical signs in the text, which were used to clarify the reading. The writer omitted "Ibn" before "Abī al-Qasim" in the name of al-Bayhaqī (on the full name, see below), or he thought erroneously it should be "Abū al-Qasim," with the genitive due to the "*li-*". The long *ā* in Sulaymān and al-Qāsim is not written with either a full or a small diacritical *alif*. The writing uses vowel signs over some letters, and *shadda* to clarify the reading, the latter also regularly over the final dotless *yā'* of the *nisba*. A small vertical stroke below the letter has been used in some places, apparently representing a short *i*, analogous to a *kasra*. The *alif* at the end of *ijtama'ū* is missing. The dots of *tā'* in *al-kitāb* are not written.

31 Cf. Wolf Dietrich Fischer, *Grammatik des Klassischen Arabisch* (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 2nd edn 1987), 138 § 195b.

32 Farès 1957, 80 n. 3; cf. Diwald 1975, 12. Hillenbrand 2006, 183, read *li-* as a particle of direction: "It has been handed down from the *Tatimma* [*sic*] *Šiwān al-Ḥikma* to [*sic*] Ṣāḥir al-Dīn Abū [*sic*] al-Qāsim al-Bayhaqī [...]." Blair 2015, 54, mistook the text as part of the preceding preface and misunderstood "La préface qui le précède se termine par l'affirmation que les épîtres ont été recueillies auprès de tous les fidèles pour Ṣāḥir al-Dīn Abī Qāsim al-Bayhaqī," and "la personne pour qui l'ouvrage a été compilé: le cheikh al-

copyist errors in the writing of the five names just because they differ from the spelling in al-Tawḥīdī's account.³³

Rather, the passage refers to al-Bayhaqī as authority on who were the authors. A comparison discloses that the text and spelling are an almost verbatim and correct quotation from his *Tatimma*.³⁴ Ḥaḥīr al-Dīn Abū al-Ḥasan 'Alī ibn Abī al-Qāsim Zayd ibn Muḥammad ibn al-Ḥusayn al-Bayhaqī, known as Ibn al-Funduq or Farīd-i Khurāsān, lived at the end of the Saljūq period (d. 565/1169). He worked in Khurāsān, in his native town Bayhaq—today, Sabzawār in eastern Iran—in Marw, Sarakhs, and Nishāpūr. He is known for a number of books, among them the Persian local history *Tārīkh-i Bayhaq*.³⁵ His *Tatimmat Ṣiwān al-ḥikma* is a bio-bibliographical work on philosophers³⁶ and, as the title implies, supplements an earlier book, the *Ṣiwān al-ḥikma* (Depository of Wisdom), attributed to the philosopher Abū al-Qāsim al-Kātib (fl. 370/980).³⁷

Two points emerge here. Firstly, against the background of the various opinions on the authorship of the *Rasā'il*, the frontispiece is a clear textual and visual statement of one particular opinion. It names and illustrates five authors of the *Rasā'il*, and it underlines the authority of this opinion by quoting from the *Tatimma* by the scholar al-Bayhaqī. Secondly, noting that the actual difference with al-Tawḥīdī's account is marginal, the significant point seems to be that a reference to a history of philosophy and a scholar from Saljuq Khurasan was preferred over an intellectual from Abbasid Baghdad. This aspect acquires more significance in the light of the patronage situation, to be discussed now before we turn to the painting.³⁸

Bayhaqī." The misunderstanding has already been spotted by Nourane Ben Azzouna in a review of Houari Touati (ed.), *De la figuration humaine au portrait dans l'art islamique* (Leiden et al.: Brill, 2015), *Der Islam* 107 (2017), 469.

33 Blair 2015, 54, thought that "Ma'sar" and "Zāhrūn" (but cf. note 29) are errors for "Ma'shar" and "Hārūn."

34 Al-Bayhaqī, *Kitāb Tatimmat Ṣiwān al-ḥikma*, edited by M. Shafī, vol. 1 (Lahore 1932), 21.

35 On al-Bayhaqī, see Douglas M. Dunlop, s. v. al-Bayhaqī, in: *ET*², vol. 1 (1960), 1131–1132; Heinz Halm, s. v. "Bayhaqī, Ḥaḥīr-al-dīn Abū'l-Ḥasan 'Alī b. Zayd," in: *Elr*, vol. 3 (1988), 895–896; Lawrence I. Conrad, s. v. "al-Bayhaqī, 'Alī ibn Zayd," in: Julie S. Meisami and Paul Starkey (eds.), *Encyclopedia of Arabic Literature*, 2 vols. (London: Routledge, 1998), vol. 1.

36 See Max Meyerhof, "Alī al-Bayhaqī's *Tatimmat Ṣiwān al-ḥikma*: A Biographical Work on Learned Men of the Islam," *Osiris* 8 (1948), 122–217; and subsequent studies.

37 The book is a history of philosophy presented as a compendium of bio-bibliographical entries on Greek and Arab philosophers and is known only through various redactions. On its authorship, see Wadād al-Qāḍī, "Kitāb Ṣiwān al-ḥikma: Structure, Composition, Authorship and Sources," *Islam* 58 (1981), 118–119, who rejects the former attribution to Abū Sulaymān Muḥammad al-Sijistānī (d. 375/985).

38 A third point, a new reading of the figures in the image based on the reading of the text heading, I am pursuing elsewhere.

3 Seeking the Patron in History: Books in Baghdad under Persian Governors

The Esad Efendi *Rasā'il* copy was commissioned at a time when Iraq had been under Ilkhan rule for almost three decades. After the turmoil and destruction of the Mongol conquest of Baghdad, the new Ilkhan rulers, who resided in north-west Iran, promoted a policy of rebuilding and continuity. Baghdad had been a centre of learning, book production, and arts of the book before the Mongol conquest, and it seems that this position was continued in the early Ilkhanid period, with many libraries and places of scholarship.³⁹ The majority of extant manuscripts made between 1259 and 1300 CE in Iraq and northwest Iran are from Baghdad.⁴⁰

Nevertheless, the framework of book patronage and the intellectual and artistic landscape had changed. A decisive aspect was the presence of Persian-speaking governors, who were sent to Baghdad to administrate Iraq. The crucial first and remarkably long period of governorship after the conquest was entrusted to members of the Persian Muslim family Juwaynī. 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Aṭā-Malik Juwaynī governed Baghdad, Iraq, and Khuzistān for one generation (657–681/1259–1283).⁴¹ He came from a family of administrators in Khurasan, which reportedly had already been serving the Saljūq and Khwārizmshāh rulers. His *nisba* refers to the plain of Juwayn, north of the road between Nishāpūr and Bisṭām.⁴² The younger brother, Shams al-Dīn, served as vizier (*ṣāhib-dīwān*) of the Ilkhanate for nearly the same long time (r. 661–683/1263–1284).⁴³ The latter's son Sharaf al-Dīn Hārūn ibn Shams al-Dīn Juwaynī followed 'Alā' al-Dīn

39 See Michael Biran, "Libraries, Books, and Transmission of Knowledge in Ilkhanid Baghdad," *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient* 62 (2019), 464–502; and Ben Azzouna 2018, *passim*.

40 Judging from the catalogue of manuscripts from both regions made in 656–814/1258–1411, in Ben Azzouna 2018, 533–567. Accordingly, from 43 copies until 1300 that mention a place (*ibid.*, nos. 1–51), 28 are from Baghdad, five each from Marāgha and Tabrīz, and one each from Hilla, Nakhjuwān, Marāgha, and Qazwīn.

41 On the early Ilkhanid period in Baghdad and Iraq, see Hend Gilly-Elewy, *Bagdad nach dem Sturz des Kalifats. Die Geschichte einer Provinz unter ilhānischer Herrschaft* (656–735/1258–1335) (Berlin: Klaus Schwarz, 2000); Javad Abbasi, "Reconstruction of Baghdad after the Mongol Invasion: 'Ata' Malik Juwayni's Tenure of Office (1259–1282)," in: *Islām Medeniyetinde Bağdat (Medinetü's-selām) Uluslararası Sempozyum*, 7–8–9 Kasım 2008; *Tebliğleri*, 2 vols. (Istanbul: Waqf of Marmara University Faculty of Theology, 2011), 283–292.

42 Gilly-Elewy 2000, 57; George E. Lane, s. v. "Jovayni, 'Alā'-al-Din 'Aṭā-Malek," in: *Elr*, vol. 15 (2009), 63–68; Clifford. E. Bosworth, s. v. "Jovayn, 3," in: *Elr*, vol. 15 (2009), 59–61.

43 Michael Biran, s. v. "Jovayni, Sāheb Divān," in: *Elr*, vol. 15 (2009), 71–74.

as governor in Baghdad for almost one year (r. 681–682/1283–1284).⁴⁴ In effect, the early Ilkhan empire in Iran and Iraq was administered for more than two decades by a Persian family from Khurasan. On the other hand, ‘Alā’ al-Dīn established local ties to the remaining caliphal family in Baghdad. He married Shams (d. 1279 CE), the widow of the Abbasid prince Aḥmad, a son of the last caliph, and he arranged the marriage of his nephew Hārūn with Rabī‘a, called Sayyida Nabawiyya, a granddaughter of the caliph.⁴⁵ Following the Juwaynīs, the Mongol Arūq was briefly governor in Baghdad until 688/1289. Subsequently, the governors changed frequently and throughout Ilkhanid rule.⁴⁶

The Juwaynī family patronized scholars, litterateurs, artists, and construction. Several authors and scholars are said to have dedicated works to the governor ‘Alā’ al-Dīn, among them Abū Yaḥyā Zakariyā’ ibn Muḥammad al-Qazwīnī’s (d. 682/1283) famous cosmography *‘Ajā’ib al-makhlūqāt*, the leading scholar Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī (d. 696/1298), and the poet Saadi (d. 691/1292). The calligrapher and musician Ṣafī al-Dīn Ūrmawī (d. 693/1294) dedicated one of his main works on musical theory, *al-Risāla al-Sharafiyya*, to Sharaf al-Dīn Hārūn, to whose *laqab* the book title alludes.⁴⁷ The renowned calligrapher Yāqūt al-Musta‘īmī (d. 696/1298) educated the children of ‘Alā’ al-Dīn and his brother in writing and calligraphy, and wrote a panegyric for Hārūn when he became governor.⁴⁸ Both Juwaynī governors were also known as scholars. ‘Alā’ al-Dīn wrote the Persian history *Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy*, an account of the Mongol conquest. A double-page frontispiece painting in a copy made in 689/1290 in Baghdad is understood to show him as a writer seated under a tree [Figs. 9–10].⁴⁹ Historiography in the period emphasizes the Juwaynīs’s build-

44 Gilli-Elewy 2000, 75; Hashem Rajabzadeh, s.v. “Jovayni Family,” in: *Elr*, vol. 15 (2009), 63.

45 Gilli-Elewy 2000, 70; Abbasi 2011, 289.

46 Gilli-Elewy 2000, 77–98.

47 Rajabzadeh 2009; Abbasi 2011, 287; T. Lewicki, s. v. “al-Kazwīnī,” in: *Elr*², vol. 4 (1977), 865. Several *‘Ajā’ib* manuscripts include a eulogy on ‘Alā’ al-Dīn, such as the illustrated copy in the British Library, Or. 14140, attributed to c. 1300 CE; see Stefano Carboni, *The Wonders of Creation and the Singularities of Painting: A Study of the Ilkhanid London Qazwīnī* (Edinburgh: University Press, 2015, 23–47, 127). The eulogy is absent from the earliest known copy, also illustrated and dated 679/1280, Munich, Bayerische Staatsbibliothek, Cod. arab. 464, as it may have been a personal copy for the author; see Syrinx von Hees, *Enzyklopädie als Spiegel des Weltbildes: Qazwīnīs Wunder der Schöpfung – eine Naturkunde des 13. Jahrhunderts* (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 2002), 85–86. Biran 2019, 492, acknowledges ‘Alā’ al-Dīn’s support for scholars but cautions that he alone cannot be credited for the cultural restoration of Baghdad.

48 Ben Azzouna 2018, 45.

49 Paris, BnF, suppl. pers. 205; see Marianna Shreve Simpson, “The Role of Baghdād in the Formation of Persian Painting,” in: Chahryar Adle (ed.), *Art et société dans le monde Iranien*

ing activities, in particular the restoration of existing and the foundation of new madrasas that offered posts for scholars,⁵⁰ followed by other patrons.⁵¹ Only a few of these buildings have survived, now much restored, in modern-day Baghdad.⁵²

A second aspect of change was the circulation of scholars and artists between Baghdad and the new Ilkhanid centres in northwest Iran, Marāgha, and Tabrīz. Regarding illustrated manuscripts, Marianna Shreve Simpson has emphasized the contribution of Baghdad, and Stefano Carboni of Iraq in general, to early Ilkhanid book painting, both affirming some continuity from pre-Mongol Iraq.⁵³ The Iraqi historian Ibn al-Fuwaṭī (642–723/1244–1323) noted that painters were brought from Baghdad to Tabrīz. His career exemplifies the scholarly link between both regions. Born in Baghdad, he experienced the Mongol conquest, migrated to work in Marāgha, and later returned to Baghdad, becoming the librarian in the famous Madrasa al-Mustanṣiriyya. From the other direction, the leading scholar Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī came from Khurasan to become director of the Ilkhan observatory in Marāgha (founded 1259 CE), acquiring books and funds from Iraq.⁵⁴

(Paris: Institut Français d'Iranologie de Téhéran, 1982), 91–116, here 111–113, who suggested Baghdad as the place of production while Richard Ettinghausen, "On Some Mongol Miniatures," *Kunst des Orients* 3 (1959), 44–52, attributed it to northwest Iran. Cf. Theresa Fitzherbert, "Portrait of a Lost Leader: Jalal al-Din Khwarazmshah and Juwaini," in: Julian Raby and Theresa Fitzherbert (eds.), *The Court of the Il-khans 1290–1340* (Oxford: University Press, 1996), 63–78, here 69–75.

50 'Alā' al-Dīn restored the late Abbasid Madrasa al-Mustanṣiriyya in 668/1270, the Saljuq al-Nizāmiyya, the al-Mughithiyya (al-Ma'ithiyya?), and the Caliphal Friday mosque, Jāmi' al-Khulafā' and its minaret in 670/1272 and 678/1280; he erected a palace with a garden in 665/1267. His wife Shams founded the Madrasa al-Ismatiyya, a large institution that taught all four Sunni doctrines and included a *ribāṭ* and a mausoleum (*turba*). See Gilly-Elewy 2000, 70–72; Abbasi 2011, 287–289; cf. Tariq Jawad al-Janabi, *Studies in Medieval Iraqi Architecture* (Baghdad: Ministry of Culture and Information, State Organization of Antiquities and Heritage, 1982), 54–56.

51 According to al-Janabi 1982, 55–56, the madrasa of Fakhr al-Dīn Abū 'Alī in 664/1265, restored by his brother Bahā' al-Dīn Ibn Qāḍī Daqūqa in 688/1289; a madrasa ordered by Majd al-Dīn ibn al-Athīr (d. 685/1285), who was buried there, the deputy of 'Alā al-Dīn al-Juwaynī, see Gilly-Elewy 2000, 66, 79; the Madrasa al-'Alā'iyya by 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Alī ibn Kurdmīr al-Turkistānī in 693/1293; the Madrasa al-Imāmiyya al-Bakriyya by the then governor Imām al-Dīn Yahyā (d. 700/1300); and the madrasa named al-Ghāzāniyya and built by Rashid al-Dīn, apparently before 704/1304.

52 The most detailed account is by al-Janabi 1982; see also Vincenzo Strika and Jābir Khalīl, *The Islamic Architecture of Baghdād: The Results of a Joint Italian-Iraqi Survey* (Naples: Istituto Universitario Orientale, 1987); and Friedrich Sarre and Ernst Herzfeld, *Archäologische Reise im Euphrat- und Tigrisgebiet*, 4 vols. (Berlin: Reimer, 1911–1920), vols. 2–3.

53 Simpson 1982, 91–116; Carboni 2015, 2–8.

54 Biran 2019, 481; 465.

A third aspect was the increased presence of Persians from Iran and Khurasan, probably attracted by Juwaynī rule. Sources report that many Iranian emigrant scholars were living in Baghdad, and that books were produced in both Arabic and Persian.⁵⁵ Almost half of the copyists of extant manuscripts made in early Ilkhanid Baghdad until 1300 have a Persian *ism* or the *nisba* of a city in Iran or Khurasan, and it appears that they worked predominantly in the Nizāmiyya Madrasa.⁵⁶ The Arabic text of the Esad Efendi *Rasā'il* was copied by Buzurj-mihr ibn Muḥammad al-Ṭūsī, a Persian name with a *nisba* referring to the city of Ṭūs in Khurasan. Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī, born in Ṭūs and educated in Nīshāpūr, moved from Marāgha to Baghdad before his death. Interestingly, almost all known manuscripts from Baghdad or attributed to Iraq that were made with painted illustrations are Persian books or were copied by persons with Persian names.⁵⁷ The 689/1290 copy of the Persian history of 'Alā' al-Dīn Juwaynī was transcribed by Rashīd Khwāfī, whose *nisba* refers to a city in Khurasan.⁵⁸ The illustrated copy of the Persian *Marzubān-nāma* of Sa'd al-Dīn al-Warawīnī, made in 698/1299 in Baghdad, was transcribed by al-Murtaẓā ibn Abī Ṭāhir ibn Aḥmad al-Kāshī, his *nisba* relating to the city of Kāshān in Central Iran.⁵⁹ The oldest known illustrated copy of the *Tārīkh-nāma* of Bal'amī, a Persian version of al-Ṭabarī's universal history *Ta'rikh al-rusul wa-l-mulūk*, has been attributed to Iraq about 1300.⁶⁰ It has been suggested that the group of illustrated *Shāh-nāma* manuscripts in small format was also produced in Baghdad at the same time, while diverging opinions attribute it to northwest Iran or other places and a later period.⁶¹

55 Ibid., 490.

56 This can be concluded from data in the catalogue of Ben Azzouna 2018, 533–567. Accordingly, eleven of 28 copyists, and of these five until 1285 CE, the time of the *Rasā'il* copy, state the Nizāmiyya as place, while two from 1294 note the Mustanṣiriyya.

57 The exception is the cosmography *'Ajā'ib* written in Arabic but by an author who had migrated from Iran. The earliest known copy of 679/1280 (Munich, Bayerische Staatsbibliothek, Cod. arab. 464) is richly illustrated and considered to have been made for the author al-Qazwīnī himself, followed by the illustrated copy c. 1300 (London, British Library, Or. 14140). Cf. in note 47.

58 See note 49.

59 Istanbul, Arkeoloji Müzesi Kütüphanesi, MS. 216; see Simpson 1982, 94–106; cf. Blair 2006, 287 n. 8.

60 Washington, D.C., Freer Gallery of Art, 47.19 and 57.16; see on the manuscript and its attribution, Teresa Fitzherbert, Bal'amī's Tabarī: An Illustrated Manuscript of Bal'amī's *Tarjama-yi Tārīkh-i Ṭabarī* in the Freer Gallery of Art, Washington (F59.16, 47.19 and 30.21), 2 vols. (University of Edinburgh: PhD Thesis, 2001), 1–2.

61 For the early attribution to Baghdad, see Marianna Shreve Simpson, *The Illustration of an Epic: The Earliest Shahnama Manuscripts* (Garland, MI: University of Michigan, 1979).

The 686/1287 *Rasā'il* copy from Baghdad contains no written evidence on who commissioned it. The inclusion of the painted double-page frontispiece with figural imagery suggests a patron of high social rank. The *Rasā'il*'s philosophical perspective and its perception as a book with Ismaili or Shiite bends as well as the figural painting would probably exclude a strictly conservative Sunni as patron. Yet, as the *Rasā'il* appears to have been highly regarded in general, it may be unwise to seek only within doctrinal borders.⁶² The copy's association with scholars from Khurasan, through the reference in the frontispiece and the copyist, may speak to someone with links to Iran.

The most likely candidate would be a member of the Juwaynī family. When the manuscript was finished, the long period of their rule in Baghdad had just ended. 'Alā' al-Dīn had died in 1283, later his nephew and successor as governor Sharaf al-Dīn Hārūn was executed in July–August 1286. Other descendants were put to death in 1289 by order of the Ilkhan Arghūn, but members of the family survived.⁶³ Still, in 1290, the copy of 'Alā' al-Dīn's *Tārīkh* was produced with his author portrait in the frontispiece [Figs. 9–10]. It is possible that, three years earlier, the *Rasā'il* copy was made for someone from the Juwaynī family or their circle. It is even possible that the copy was ordered by Sharaf al-Dīn Hārūn before his death and then finished a year later, in November–December 1287. The scenario is speculative, but Hārūn would be a plausible patron: he was considered a learned man, carrying the byname *khwāja*, and he lectured as scholar at the Madrasa al-Nizāmiyya restored by 'Alā' al-Dīn.⁶⁴ We will return to this hypothesis after considering now the paintings in the frontispiece.

4 Seeing the Patron in the Frontispiece: Figures with Book and the Architecture

The question of how the patron is represented in the double-page frontispiece of the *Rasā'il* copy from Ilkhanid Baghdad has not been posed in previous scholarship. For Arab book painting, this question is usually considered for another

Sheila S. Blair and Jonathan M. Bloom, *The Art and Architecture of Islam 1250–1800* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1994), 34, opt for Tabriz in the 1330s and 1340s.

62 Such as the local Shiite establishment in Baghdad, or among candidates like Ghiyāth al-Dīn Ibn Tāwūs (d. 693/1294), leader (*naqīb*) of the 'Alid families in Baghdad, whose house was a place of learning with a library frequented by many scholars; see Biran 2019, 478.

63 On the dates of death, see Rajabzadeh 2009.

64 Ibid., 63; Abbasi 2011, 287 n. 24. Cf. note 50.

theme of frontispiece painting, the enthroned prince with entourage, at the very beginning of the book.⁶⁵ It is not impossible that the missing beginning of the *Rasā'il* copy included also a frontispiece. Yet analysis of the existing double page painting suggests visual references to the patron and his milieu, in the figures and the architecture of the setting.

What is striking about two figures on the ground floor is that they both are depicted presenting a book, which could point to the *Rasā'il* copy. The first, on the right-hand page, is the large seated figure on the right, who holds a book in one hand that has illegible letters on the cover [Fig. 8]. This cannot be the patron, however, as, following the interpretation sketched above, the figure would depict the scholar al-Bayhaqī. Hence, the painter shows him with his book *Tatimma*, which is mentioned and quoted in the text above the painting. His first place in the sequence of the large seated figures corresponds to the first place of his name and book in that text. The painter has clearly distinguished him from the author figures by giving him a face with narrow slit-like eyes and a dark complexion, the latter a feature that, in Arabic book painting, usually designates an ethnic alterity as non-Arab.⁶⁶

More pertinent is the small figure standing on the far left of the left page, who reverently holds a book in both hands, in front of his chest [Fig. 7]. This figure has been interpreted as a servant, like the other three small, standing figures flanking the large seated figures.⁶⁷ Yet, among these figures, he is the only person shown with a large golden nimbus around the head, a feature that connects him to the large seated figures. His significance is further underlined by the frontal view of his body, an aspect that heightens the importance of the middle person in the two groups of large seated figures. The face has distinct features, clearly different from the large seated figures: rounded and with a Mongol beard style, a thin moustache in two halves, which starts over the mouth corners, and a strip on the chin. Here the painter might communicate a difference in time and place: the large figures represent individuals of Abbasid and Saljuq times, the small figure would be a person of the Ilkhanid present, though not necessarily a Mongol.

65 See on the interpretation of such frontispieces, Contadini 2012, 55–62; Robert Hillenbrand, “The Frontispiece Problem in the Early 13th-Century *Kitāb al-Aghānī*,” in: Martina Müller-Wiener and Lorenz Korn (eds.), *Central periphery? Art, Culture and History of the Medieval Jazira (Northern Mesopotamia, 8th–15th Centuries)* (Wiesbaden: Reichert, 2018), 199–228; Blair 2015, 56–61.

66 As noted by Contadini 2012, 76.

67 Ettinghausen 1962, 102; Hillenbrand 2006, 207.



FIGURE 7
Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā',
 Baghdad 686/1287. Small standing figure
 presenting a book, on the left of the left
 frontispiece page, possibly representing the
 patron or a maker of the copy. MS Istanbul,
 Esad Efendi 3638, fol. 4a, detail
 PHOTO © SYEK

The man's posture, standing with arms held in front of his chest and looking respectfully towards the central figures, is reminiscent of attendants in Persian court imagery since the Sasanian period, and is seen in illustrations of the Ilkhanid *Great Mongol Shāhnāme* attributed to Tabrīz in 1330–1340 CE.⁶⁸ It differs from the book-holding figures in the author portrait of the well-known Dioscorides manuscript, attributed to the Jazīra and dated 626/1229, commonly interpreted as students who are presenting copies to the author.⁶⁹ The iconography of a court attendant with the attribute of a book in his hands, could here denote the patron of the *Rasā'il* copy or a maker who was responsible for producing it, shown in the posture of a reverential attendant to the assembly of authors and scholars. Two more features support this interpretation. Firstly, in

68 See Oleg Grabar and Sheila Blair, *Epic Images and Contemporary History: The Illustrations of the Great Mongol Shahnāma* (Chicago, IL: University Press, 1980), Nos. 11, 12, 17, 28, 57. Cf. Robert Hillenbrand, *The Great Mongol Shahnāma* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2022), fig. 3.18; 4.11 and p. 15; 5.6; 7.3 and p. 20; 14.7.

69 Istanbul, TSMK Ahmet III, 2127 fol. 1b–2a; Ettinghausen 1962, 67–70.



FIGURE 8

Rasā'il Ikhwān al-ṣafā' wa-khullān al-wafā', Baghdad 686/1287. Large seated figure holding a book, on the right of the right frontispiece page, here identified as the scholar al-Bayhaqī with his book *Tatimma*, mentioned in the text above the painting, shown with a face similar to that of 'Alā' al-Dīn Juwaynī in Fig. 9. MS Istanbul, Esad Efendi 3638, fol. 3b, detail

PHOTO © SYEK

the general layout of the double page, it is the text box on this, the left page that displays the *Rasā'il* book title in large letters. This allows us to associate the book held by the figure on this page with the *Rasā'il* copy and the figure holding it with its making. Secondly, following the reading direction from right to left, this figure ends the line of figures on the ground floor and guides us to the overleaf page where the first chapter of the *Rasā'il* starts, again suggesting that the person is someone related to the making of the copy. That the figure is standing and smaller than the seated author figures does not invalidate the interpretation. All the figures in the contemporary frontispiece of the *Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy* are also smaller than the seated author, including a person in luxurious garments who stands in front of him and might represent the



FIGURE 9
Standing figure presenting a book, identified in the inscription as Ḥusayn 'Alī Khān Mu'ayyir al-Mamālīk, who holds one volume of the *Hazār wa yik shab* from the book project that he directed. Water colour on paper, 18×24 cm. Tehran, signed and dated Abū al-Ḥasan Khān Ghaffārī 1270/1854. Moayyer ol-Mamalek Family Collection ZOKA 2003, FIG. 69

patron of the copy [Fig. 11]. As we know of no earlier parallel for the iconography in the *Rasā'il* frontispiece, i.e. standing like a court attendant and with the attribute of a book, it may have been newly formulated at the time. Much later evidence of such a visual formula is the portrait of Ḥusayn 'Alī Khān Mu'ayyir al-Mamālīk (d. 1858) who directed the production of the Persian multi-volume illustrated *Hazār wa yik shab*. He is depicted as a standing figure presenting one volume of the work, in a painting of Abū al-Ḥasan Khān Ghaffārī, dated 1270/1854 [Fig. 9].⁷⁰

⁷⁰ On the book project and this painting, see Yahya Zoka, *Life and Works of Sanī' ol-Molk Abol-Hasan Ghaffārī 1814–1866* (Tehran: Iran University Press, 2003), 84, fig. 69.



FIGURE 10

Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy of 'Alā' al-Dīn Juwaynī, dated 689/1290, attributed to Baghdad. Seated writing figure, identified as the author 'Alā' al-Dīn (Juwaynī) with the title *Ṣāhib-Dīwān* in the inscription at the head. MS Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, ms. suppl. pers. 205, fol. 2a, detail

PHOTO GALLICA © BNF



FIGURE 11 Frontispiece in the *Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy* of 'Alā' al-Dīn Juwaynī, dated 689/1290, attributed to Baghdad. Water colour on paper, pages 33 × 25 cm. On the left, seated writing figure identified in the inscription as authors and standing figure in rich garments; on the right, kneeling groom and white horse with rich saddle. MS Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France, ms. suppl. pers. 205, fols. 1b–2a

PHOTO GALLICA © BNF

The luxurious architecture that structures and frames the scene could be a way of representing the patron's milieu. A tripartite, two-storey building has been used before in Iraqi book illustration as a visual formula for residences of high-ranking persons. For example, in illustrations of the copy of al-Ḥarīrī's *Maqāmāt*, painted by Yahyā ibn Maḥmūd al-Wāsiṭī and dated 634/1237, such a building denotes a palace of the governor or king,⁷¹ and likewise in an illustration of the *Kitāb al-Dīryāq* dated 595/1199.⁷² Later, the formula is consistently used in the *Great Mongol Shāhnāma*, with palaces depicted as a high room flanked by two storeys.⁷³ The painted architecture in the frontispiece has been compared with extant Ilkhanid architecture in Iran and seen as a free-standing polygonal building or pavilion, on account of the slanted sides.⁷⁴ These sides, however, can also be interpreted as the receding or protruding lateral sides of a building on a rectangular plan.⁷⁵

In view of the manuscript's making in Baghdad, it may be more fitting to consider Iraqi architecture in order to understand what may have been meant. The two paintings show a mixed brick and wood two-storey structure. Slender wooden columns on the ground floor carry a horizontal architrave. The upper floor is a gallery, lower in height, with smaller broken-headed arches. On the ground floor, the middle section is fully open, and the side sections are closed by balustrades, like in the gallery, probably meant to represent painted wood. The ornamented gallery arches on thin supports also appear to refer to a light material, such as wood or stucco. The two storeys are set on a high plinth of five horizontally and one vertically laid courses of bricks, a standard type of masonry seen, for example, at the base of the early Ilkhanid Ṣūq al-Ghazl minaret in Baghdad.⁷⁶ In the middle of this plain wall, an opening with a broken-headed arch, similar to the gallery arches, is shown. This can be a half-storey base, which raises the building above the ground; or, since it is as high as the gallery, it may indicate a full lower storey with an opening. Under the slanted sides, blue triangles with white coils seem to indicate water.⁷⁷

71 Paris, BnF, Arabe 5847, fols. 122b (see Ettinghausen 1962, 121), 120b, 88a. Yet, in two other paintings, it shows, more prosaically, a wine pub, fol. 32a, and a shop, fol. 105a.

72 Paris, BnF, Arabe 2964, p. 27; see Ettinghausen 1962, 85.

73 Grabar/Blair 1980, nos. 1, 15, 17, 52. Cf. Hillenbrand 2022, fig. 1.3, 7.12, 7.15, 14.7. There are several other illustrations of a palace as single-storey tripartite architecture.

74 Hillenbrand 2006, 198–203, concedes that such a building type is known only from later periods in Iran.

75 As seen in the *Great Mongol Shahnama*, Grabar/Blair 1980, nr. 46, and Hillenbrand 2022, fig. 9.13, or in a sketch attributed to c. 1400, in the *Diez-Alben*; see Berlin, Staatsbibliothek, Orientabteilung, Diez A Fol. 70, 26 (Ipşiroğlu 1971, fig. 71).

76 Sarre/Herzfeld 1911–1920, vol. 2, 156–159, vol. 3, pl. 47b, 48b, 49d.

77 Hillenbrand 2006, 200, noted the use of the water formula.

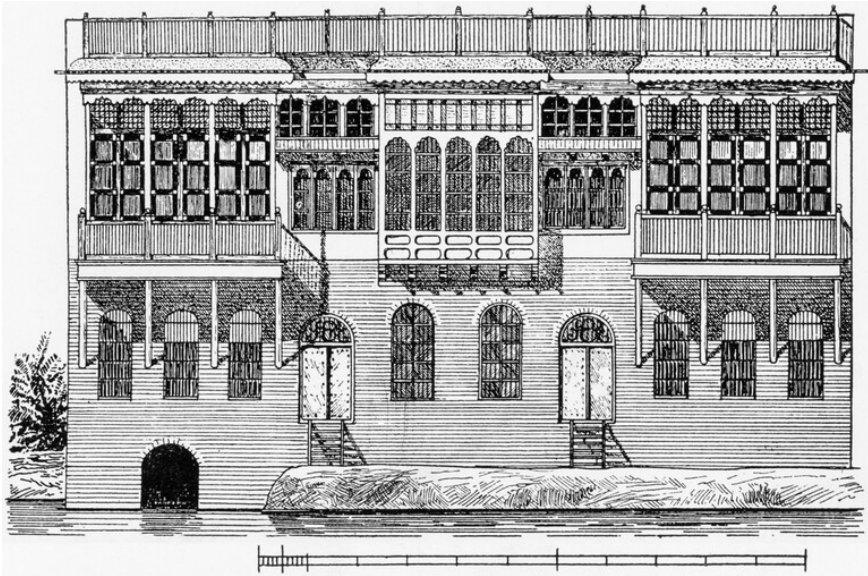


FIGURE 12 River front residence at the Tigris in Baghdad, nineteenth century, drawing
LANGENEGGER 1911, FIG. 183, DETAIL

The depiction may well refer to forms of local architecture in Baghdad, made of brick and wood and known, unfortunately, only from much later periods. Even so, it is instructive to note analogies such as the galleries with slender wooden columns, and the flat roof over a lower storey in the Khān Firmān, said to go back to the sixteenth century but largely from the nineteenth century.⁷⁸ The reference to water is reminiscent of riverfront residences and buildings along the Tigris, with two storeys, loggias and galleries, and a lower storey with a water door for boats, situated directly at the water's edge, such as those seen in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century photographs and drawings from Baghdad [Fig. 12].⁷⁹

⁷⁸ Strika/Khalil 1987, 35, pl. ix b.

⁷⁹ Felix Langenegger, *Die Baukunst des Irâq (Heutiges Babylonien). Bautechnik, Baukonstruktionen und Aussehen der Baugegenstände unter teilweiser Bezugnahme auf die Baukunst der Vergangenheit des Landes sowie auf die gesamte Baukunst des Islâm* (Dresden: Gerhard Kühtmann, 1911), figs. 75–76, 183; Caecilia Pieri, *Baghdad Arts Deco: Architectural Brickwork 1920–1950* (Cairo: The American University in Cairo Press, 2010), [viii], 21, 22.

5 Conclusion: An Author Portrait as Statement of the Patron

The examination of the 686/1287 copy of the *Rasā'il* shows that part of the preface and one or more opening pages are missing. It confirms that the frontispiece is an integral part of the manuscript, and provides internal evidence for the history of the codex. The manuscript has two colophons that state the date, differing by one month, the place of production, and the name of the copyist al-Ṭuṣī, but there is no written evidence of the patron. In the Ottoman period, the manuscript was restored, the folios were cropped, and it received its present binding. Probably at this time, part of the manuscript was replaced with rewritten folios, and the present first folio was added. Its study note and the ownership record of a scribe of the Deputy Grand Vizier attest to Ottoman use before the book entered the collection of Esad Efendi in Istanbul.

The main distinguishing feature, unique among known *Rasā'il* copies, is the double-page frontispiece, which announces the book's authors both in writing and with a compelling and vibrant, narrative figural image [Fig. 1]. While it has been commonly seen as the continuity of author and multi-author portraits in frontispieces of manuscripts of pre-Mongol Iraq, Blair has pointed to the novelty of an image that closely illustrates a text, that is, the headlines above the painting.⁸⁰ The present contribution underlines the conceptual and artistic innovation in terms of layers of function and meaning.

One layer is its function as editorial statement, and that this statement must have reflected the position of the patron of the copy. Placed not at the beginning but between preface and first chapter, the double page provided written and visual emphasis to one opinion and one specific authority in the medieval debate on who the authors were. The text in the frontispiece spelled the names of a group of five authors, quoting from the history of philosophy by al-Bayhaqi. The painting illustrates these six individuals, the quoted scholar with his book and the five *Rasā'il* authors, as the large figures of a learned assembly. They are surrounded by smaller figures, representing students and assistants. The quotation from al-Bayhaqi may have been chosen because a reference to his scholarly *Tatimma* was preferred over al-Tawhīdī's literary account, although both reported almost the same. But it may also have reflected and showcased the patron's preference for a scholarly tradition that was related to Khurasan. This tradition would have been known and mediated by the copyist al-Ṭuṣī, a Persian from Khurasan, whose work suggests that he must have had some scholarly education or was a scholar himself. The copy with the frontispiece

⁸⁰ Blair 2015, 54, 55.

could reflect the reception of the *Rasā'il* in Persian scholarly traditions and their westward migration.

In another layer, this image of authors seems to include references to the patron or maker of the copy and to his milieu. It reaffirms a personal attachment to the statement made by the frontispiece. The figure standing on the far left with a book in his hands appears on the page with the book title of the *Rasā'il* and is distinguished by a golden nimbus, suggestive of a patron presenting the copy of the book, or a person involved in its making [Fig. 7]. The architectural setting represents, literally or as a sign, his social standing and the patronage of scholars. It could refer to a scholarly assembly in a private residence, or in a madrasa or *ribāṭ*. The luxury of gilded columns and patterned curtains evokes a wealthy milieu, and the reference to water is reminiscent of the riverfront buildings on the Tigris in Baghdad. Speculating from the perspective of patronage at that time, the unknown patron could well have been from the Juwaynī family of governors at Baghdad, possibly the scholar and short-term governor Sharaf al-Dīn Hārūn Juwaynī.

Among the formal particularities of the image is the individualized depiction of the figures, particularly those on the ground floor, which contrasts with the schematic author figures of earlier author portraits.⁸¹ A further, more conceptual departure would be the use of facial features to indicate time and place, and the portrayal of contemporaneous persons in the faces of figures, used as references to the patron or his family. The face of the first large seated figure, here interpreted as a depiction of al-Bayhaqī [Fig. 8], is strikingly similar to 'Alā' al-Dīn Juwaynī in the frontispiece of his *Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy*, painted three years later [Fig. 10].⁸² Both faces show the same type, with an elongated outline, narrow elongated slit-like eyes, high and rather straight brows, a long beard from cheek and chin down to the breast, and a moustache, which is slightly different in the later image, with long curved tips pointing downwards. To be sure, the presence of 'Alā' al-Dīn's face in the *Rasā'il* image could scarcely mean that he was the patron of the copy; indeed, he had died four years before the text was finished. But if this was a 'hidden' or crypto-portrait of him, the painter gave it to the most fitting figure: large, honourably seated in the first place, and representing a person who, like him, was from Khurasan. In this case, the figure on the far left holding a book would represent the patron or a maker of the copy and thus should also be considered a portrait [Fig. 7]. The facial features

81 This aspect needs to be elaborated. For the time being, see Hillenbrand 2006, and the examples in Contadini 2012, 55–62.

82 Paris, BnF, suppl. pers. 205; the identification is suggested by the inscription, probably later added, to his right; see Ettinghausen 1959; Simpson 1982, 111–113.

might denote a Mongol, such as the then governor Arūq. Yet shown small and as attendant, a junior Juwaynī may have been represented, perhaps Sharaf al-Dīn Hārūn, discussed above. The difference between the two figures, in terms of size and posture, would appropriately convey a respectful hierarchy between the uncle ‘Alā’ al-Dīn and the nephew Hārūn. Their parallel presence in the image would turn it into a memento of Juwaynī patronage at a time when the family had just been removed from power, and one wonders whether more figures in the image have been painted with portrait faces.

Further discussion may substantiate that the 686/1287 *Rasā’il* copy from Ilkhanid Baghdad not only was furnished with a novel form and function of an authors’ portrait, but also painted with a new concept of visually commenting history and present. It functioned as an editorial statement on the authorship of the book, with a painting that visualized a text on the history of that book, quoted from a historiography of philosophy. At the same time, the painting referred to Ilkhanid Baghdad, showing the scholarly assembly in architecture of that city and pointing to the Juwaynī governors, with at least one or two portraits projected onto faces of the figures. While similar concepts have been pinned to the production of illustrated Ilkhanid manuscripts in northwest Iran in the years 1310–1340 CE, Theresa Fitzherbert has shown them also in the frontispiece painting of the 689/1290 copy of Juwaynī’s *Tārīkh-i Jahān-gushāy*, probably made in Baghdad.⁸³ The *Rasā’il* double page painting, securely localized, turns out to be an earlier, in some respect even more layered manifest of such image concept in Baghdad.

Conspectus of Manuscripts

Istanbul, Arkeoloji Müzesi Kütüphanesi MS. 216	London, British Library Or. 14140
Istanbul, Süleymaniye Kütüphanesi Esad Efendi 3638	Munich, Bayerische Staatsbibliothek Cod. Arab. 464
Istanbul, Topkapı Sarayı Müzesi Kütüphanesi Ahmet III 2127 Ahmet III 2921 Ahmet III 2922	Paris, Bibliothèque nationale de France Arabe 2964 Arabe 5847 Supplément persan 205

83 Fitzherbert 1996, 63, 75.